

Your First Month with Hearing Aids

Category: Use Your Tools Well

Best for: New hearing aid users, adults preparing for a hearing aid fitting, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and systematic review sources

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Why the first month matters

The first month with hearing aids is an adjustment period. Hearing aids can improve access to speech and everyday sounds, but they do not make hearing normal. Many adults need time, practice, and follow-up care before hearing aids feel natural.

During the first month, your goals are to learn how to use your hearing aids, build a consistent wearing routine, notice what sounds better, notice what is still difficult, identify comfort or sound-quality concerns, practice communication strategies, and prepare useful feedback for your audiologist.

Hearing aids may sound different at first

Some sounds may seem louder, sharper, brighter, or more noticeable than you expected. Your own voice may also sound different. You may suddenly notice paper crinkling, dishes clinking, water running, footsteps, air conditioning, car signals, birds, clothing brushing against the microphone, chewing, swallowing, and speech sounds like /s/, /f/, /sh/, and /t/.

This does not automatically mean something is wrong. If you have had hearing loss for a while, your brain may not have received certain sounds clearly for a long time. However, sound should not be painful or intolerable. If your hearing aids are painfully loud, physically uncomfortable, distorted, or causing significant irritation, contact your audiologist.

Wear them consistently, but build up safely if needed

Consistent use is important. Hearing aids usually work best when they are worn regularly during waking hours. Some people can wear hearing aids most of the day right away. Others may need to build up gradually.

Try not to save your hearing aids only for the hardest situations, such as restaurants or large family gatherings. Those environments are challenging, even for experienced hearing-aid users.

Start with easier listening situations

Practice in quiet, familiar places first. Try talking with one person at home, watching television at a comfortable volume, listening to familiar voices, taking a short walk in a quiet area, reading aloud, and noticing everyday household sounds.

Background noise may still be difficult

Hearing aids can help with speech and environmental sounds, but they cannot remove all background noise. In noise, you may still need strategies such as sitting close, facing the speaker, choosing quieter seating, asking people to speak one at a time, using captions, or asking about a remote microphone.

Follow-up appointments are part of the process

A hearing-aid fitting is usually not the final step. Follow-up appointments are important because real-life listening gives information that cannot always be predicted in the clinic. Follow-up care is a normal part of successful hearing-aid use.

Keep track of what works and what does not

Bring specific examples to your audiologist. Examples include: "My own voice sounds hollow," "Dishes and paper are too sharp," "Restaurants are still very hard," "The left hearing aid feels loose," or "Phone calls are clearer, but video calls are difficult."

Learn basic care and troubleshooting

Ask your audiologist how to put the hearing aids in, remove them safely, tell right and left apart, charge them or change batteries, clean them, change wax guards if appropriate, store them safely, and use the app or volume control.

References

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